

# HOW COMMUNITIES CAN STOP DESTRUCTIVE DEVELOPMENT PROJECTS IN CHAD

## INTRODUCTION & FRAMEWORK

Chad's environmental life turns above all on **Lake Chad**, the great transboundary lake it shares with Nigeria, Niger, and Cameroon, on which tens of millions depend for fishing, farming, and herding. The lake shrank drastically in the droughts of the 1970s and 1980s and became a symbol of a warming world; but the honest, more recent science is that it is not simply vanishing — it fluctuates with the rains, has partly recovered, and its communities have long adapted to its rising and falling. The real crisis of the basin is not a lake quietly disappearing but a tangle of variable water, deep poverty, and a long insurgency that has displaced millions — a tangle no single fix can cut. Into this has come **Transaqua**, a vast proposal to refill the lake by diverting water from the distant Congo basin, warned by many to be a costly, risky scheme that could devastate the Congo basin and flood Chad's own lands. And Chad has **oil**, whose pipeline was once a famous experiment in turning oil money to the good of the people — an experiment that failed. The nation is poor and under military rule, and much of the region is insecure. But the truth about the lake, and the scrutiny of the grand fixes, give real ground.

Those who would defend the basin's people work with real, if constrained, tools, all worked carefully and grounded in truth. The strongest is **honest science**: the accurate hydrology of Lake Chad, which fluctuates rather than simply vanishes, is itself a corrective to the false premise behind the risky grand fix. That grand scheme — **Transaqua**, the proposed diversion of Congo-basin water — can and must be **rigorously scrutinised** through environmental review and the transboundary frameworks, for its transboundary harm, its flood risk to Chad's own lands, and its questionable premise. The **transboundary lake and river frameworks** — the Lake Chad Basin Commission, the international water regimes, and the Congo basin's own stake — govern the shared waters and reach the schemes. The **oil and its broken revenue promises and community harms** can be held to account, through its financiers and the record of a failed experiment. And the **humanitarian stakes of the basin** reach the world and its conscience — a channel and a lever. But these tools have grave limits, and this guide states them plainly. The lake's story is complex and its science contested, so honest science and adaptation, not a single dramatic rescue, are the realistic path. The poverty and the long insurgency are real and beyond easy remedy, and much of the region is insecure and dangerous. The nation is poor and under military rule. And, above all, the vulnerable communities and any local advocates must be protected, and the conflict zones avoided entirely. And though Lake Chad and the grand fixes define the struggle here, the same careful tools reach any other harmful project — environmental review, the functioning institutions and transboundary frameworks, and honest science — the lake remaining the central case. So the work must be careful, honest-science-grounded, and framed around the livelihoods and the frameworks, never around challenging authority — and the honest prize is a risky scheme scrutinised, the oil held to account, and the lake's true livelihoods defended, not a project stopped by confrontation.

## The Whole Strategy in One Idea

You cannot cut the basin's tangle of water, poverty, and conflict with a single stroke, and you cannot safely mount open confrontation under military rule in an insecure land. What you can do is ground everything in honest science: correct the false premise behind the risky grand fix, scrutinise Transaqua for its real harms through the transboundary frameworks, hold the oil to account for its broken promises, and carry the

humanitarian stake to the world — carefully, protecting the vulnerable, and avoiding the conflict zones.

## Be Honest About Which Fight You're In

Chad is a poor, conflict-touched, military-ruled setting, and honesty about that is the first discipline — including honesty about the lake itself, whose story is more complex than the headlines. This is not a fight you win by confrontation, nor by embracing a dramatic rescue. It is a careful, science-grounded effort whose realistic prize is a risky scheme scrutinised, the oil held to account, and the lake's true livelihoods defended — not a single triumphant fix. Frame everything around honest science and the livelihoods, protect the vulnerable, and avoid the dangerous areas entirely.

## HOW THE SYSTEM WORKS

### Who Actually Decides

Power rests with a military-led state in a poor, insecure, conflict-touched nation. But the decisions a careful effort can reach run through the channels that function and reach from outside: the **transboundary Lake Chad Basin Commission and the Congo basin bodies**, the **scientific and technical community** that holds the honest hydrology, the **international financiers and standards** behind the oil and any grand scheme, and the **humanitarian and international frameworks and partners**. Map who decides, and where it is safe to act, before spending a week on it.

### How a Project Moves — and Where You Jump In

A grand scheme like Transaqua, or an oil development, advances through national decision and international finance, and — for the shared waters — must reckon with the transboundary frameworks. The point of entry is the science and the scrutiny: correcting the false premise, demanding a rigorous environmental and transboundary assessment, and invoking the basin frameworks. For the oil, the entry point is the record of broken promises and the financiers' standards. Enter always where it is safe, grounded in honest science.

### Follow the Money and the Permissions

Follow the water: what a scheme would divert or flood, what the honest hydrology shows, and what the transboundary frameworks require. Follow the finance: which international financiers and partners stand behind Transaqua or the oil, and what standards they answer to. Follow the record: the oil's broken revenue promises and community harms. The leverage lies in the honest science, the transboundary frameworks, the financiers' standards, and the record of failure.

### Who's Supposed to Be Watching

Domestic oversight is weak in a poor, military-ruled state, but the transboundary Lake Chad Basin Commission and the Congo basin bodies, the international scientific community, the financiers and their standards, and the humanitarian and international frameworks are the channels a careful case engages — holding each to the honest science, the transboundary obligations, and the standards.

## QUICK REFERENCE: SUCCESS RATES

No Chadian effort easily halts a grand scheme or the oil, and honesty requires saying so — the nation is poor and troubled and the science contested. But the honest hydrology, the transboundary frameworks, and

the record of the oil are real. The single most decisive move is **grounding everything in honest science**, because the accurate truth about the lake is itself a corrective to the false premise behind the risky fix, and because credible evidence is what the frameworks, the financiers, and the world respond to. The scrutiny of the grand scheme is the sharpest lever; the transboundary frameworks the distinctive one; the oil's record the clearest accountability. The realistic prize is a risky scheme scrutinised and slowed, the oil held to account, and the true livelihoods defended — pursued carefully and safely.

## STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION

Ask five questions. **What is the harm?** — the risky diversion scheme, the flood risk, the oil's community and revenue harms, the threat to the real livelihoods. **What is the honest science?** — the accurate hydrology that corrects the false premise. **Which framework does it touch?** — the Lake Chad Basin Commission, the Congo basin, the international water regimes. **Who stands behind it?** — the financiers and partners, and the standards they answer to. **How is everyone kept safe?** — the overriding question, answered by staying science-grounded, protecting the vulnerable, and avoiding the conflict zones. Pick the harm where the honest science and the frameworks offer the clearest, safest handle.

## STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION — HOW TO BUILD AN UNASSAILABLE CASE

Build the case in layers, grounded in honest science. **Layer one: the truth and the harm** — the accurate hydrology of the lake, the real harms of the grand scheme (transboundary damage, flood risk, questionable premise), the oil's broken promises and community harms. **Layer two: the framework and the standard** — the transboundary obligations the scheme touches, the environmental review it must undergo, the standards its financiers answer to. **Layer three: the channel and the safety** — which framework, scientific body, or financier to reach, and the absolute discipline of protecting the vulnerable, avoiding the conflict zones, and framing everything around science and livelihoods, not authority. A case built on honest hydrology and the transboundary frameworks is the one that carries weight without endangering anyone.

## WHAT TO GATHER, AND WHERE TO FIND IT

Gather the **science record**: the accurate hydrology of Lake Chad, the studies of its fluctuation and adaptation, the real harms of the grand scheme. Gather the **framework record**: the Lake Chad Basin Commission and Congo basin obligations, the international water regimes, the environmental-review requirements. Gather the **finance record**: the financiers and partners behind Transaqua and the oil, and the standards they answer to, and the oil's record of failure. Gather the **channel record**: the scientific community, the framework bodies, the humanitarian and international partners. Gather the **safety discipline**: confirm the case stays science-grounded, protects the vulnerable, and avoids the conflict zones.

## STEP 3: BUILDING THE SCIENTIFIC, COMMUNITY & INTERNATIONAL COALITION

Build the coalition carefully and only where it is safe: the **fishing, farming, and herding communities** whose true livelihoods are at stake; the **scientific and technical community** that holds the honest hydrology; the **transboundary framework bodies and the Congo basin's own stakeholders**, who share the concern over a risky diversion; and the **humanitarian and international partners** who can reach the

financiers and the world. Frame the effort around honest science and the livelihoods, never around challenging authority; protect the vulnerable and any advocates absolutely; and avoid the conflict zones entirely.

## STEP 4: SCIENCE, SCRUTINY & TRANSBOUNDARY LEVERS — CONTESTING THE HARM CAREFULLY

Set expectations honestly: the levers are real but constrained, the science contested, and the work must be careful and safe.

### Honest Science and the Scrutiny of the Scheme

The strongest lever is **honest science**: the accurate hydrology that shows the lake fluctuates rather than simply vanishing corrects the false premise behind the risky grand fix. On that ground, **Transaqua** and any grand scheme can be **rigorously scrutinised** — for its transboundary harm to the Congo basin, its flood risk to Chad's lands, and its questionable premise — through environmental review and the frameworks.

### The Transboundary Frameworks

The distinctive lever is the **transboundary lake and river frameworks** — the Lake Chad Basin Commission, the international water regimes, and the Congo basin's own stake. A diversion that harms four nations and a second basin is not one state's to decide, and the shared frameworks give a case a transboundary lever.

### The Oil Accountability and the Humanitarian Stake

The **oil's broken revenue promises and community harms** can be held to account through its financiers and the record of a failed experiment, and the **humanitarian stakes of the basin** reach the world and its conscience. Pursued together — the honest science and scrutiny, the frameworks, and the oil accountability — these levers contest the harm carefully, while protecting the vulnerable and avoiding the conflict zones.

## TURNING YOUR EVIDENCE INTO ARGUMENTS

Tailor the case, always grounded in honest science. **For the framework bodies**: here is a diversion that harms the shared waters and a second basin, and the transboundary obligation it offends. **For the scientific community**: here is the accurate hydrology that corrects the false premise behind the risky fix. **For the financiers**: here is a scheme, or an oil development, that fails the standards you answer to. **For the world**: here is the humanitarian stake, and the true path of honest science and defended livelihoods. **The golden rule**: ground everything in honest science and the livelihoods, never in challenging authority; protect the vulnerable; and avoid the conflict zones — that is the safe and effective register here.

## STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY

Media must be handled with care under military rule and amid conflict. Frame the story around **honest science and the livelihoods**: the true, complex story of the lake, the real harms of a risky grand fix, and the fishing, farming, and herding communities who depend on the basin — never around challenging authority. Carry it through the scientific press, the transboundary and humanitarian networks, and the international outlets. A few cautions govern everything: keep it science-grounded; never frame it as a challenge to the government; protect the vulnerable and any advocates; avoid the conflict actors; and let the honest

hydrology and the transboundary stakes carry the weight.

## EMAILS & LETTERS

Keep every message factual, science-grounded, protective of the vulnerable, and clear of the conflict.

**8A — To the Lake Chad Basin Commission:** set out the shared-waters harm of the grand scheme and request the framework's scrutiny.

**8B — To a Congo basin body or stakeholder:** flag the transboundary harm a diversion would bring, and ask for engagement.

**8C — To the scientific community:** present the accurate hydrology and request technical assessment of the scheme's premise and harms.

**8D — To an international water regime:** connect the diversion to the transboundary obligations and request attention.

**8E — To a financier:** ask how the scheme or the oil meets the standards the institution answers to, with the evidence.

**8F — On the oil accountability:** document the broken revenue promises and community harms and press for accountability.

**8G — To a humanitarian or international partner:** describe the basin's stake and request engagement.

**8H — To the international public:** summarise the honest story and the risky fix, and ask for scrutiny — without exposing anyone.

## IF YOU HAVE LITTLE TIME: THE RAPID-FIRE VERSION

**The first 48 hours:** assemble the honest hydrology and the real harms of the grand scheme; write the one-page science-and-scrutiny case; identify the safest channel — usually the framework bodies or the scientific community. **The fastest-moving levers:** honest science, the transboundary frameworks, and the financiers' standards. **Emergency coalition-building:** reach the scientific community and the framework bodies first — safely and science-grounded. Throughout, protect the vulnerable and avoid the conflict zones.

## WHEN THE SYSTEM IS TILTED

The field here is tilted by military rule, deep poverty, conflict, and a contested science that a dramatic rescue exploits. Recognise it and adjust the aim — not a triumphant fix, but a risky scheme scrutinised and the true livelihoods defended. Lean on the levers the tilt cannot easily reach: the honest science, the transboundary frameworks, the financiers' standards, the humanitarian stake. And accept the honest limits — the tangle of water, poverty, and conflict is beyond any single fix — while still scrutinising the harm and defending the truth, and protecting the vulnerable.

## WHEN IT'S ACTUAL CORRUPTION — AND WHO BENEFITS

Distinguish the ordinary tilt from capture — a grand scheme championed for the contracts it brings, oil revenue that vanished as the failed experiment showed, deals steered to insiders. Where capture appears, respond only through the **safe channels**: the honest science, the transboundary frameworks, the financiers'

standards, the international record. Never through anything touching the conflict or challenging authority openly. **On safety and care:** this note matters most of all. Chad is under military rule and much of the region is touched by conflict, insecurity, and a great refugee crisis. Favour the community, technical, and international channels over open confrontation; protect individuals absolutely, especially the vulnerable and any advocates; frame the work around honest science, the livelihoods, and the frameworks, never around challenging authority; and avoid the conflict zones and armed actors entirely. Care is the first rule.

## INTEGRATION & TIMELINE: RUNNING ALL FIVE STEPS TOGETHER

The steps run in parallel, science-grounded and only where safe. The honest hydrology feeds the scheme's scrutiny, the transboundary appeal, and the oil accountability at once; the scientific, community, and international coalition organises carefully alongside; the media carries the honest-science frame throughout. A rough timeline: **weeks one to four**, assemble the science and the real harms, safely; **months two to six**, press the frameworks, the scientific bodies, the financiers, and the oil accountability; **beyond**, sustain the scrutiny and the defence of the true livelihoods. The core discipline: honest-science-grounded, framework-driven, careful, and absolute in protecting the vulnerable and avoiding the conflict.

## FINAL ASSESSMENT

Chad is a poor, conflict-touched, military-ruled ground, and this guide does not pretend otherwise — including that the lake's own story is more complex than the headlines. It does not claim the basin's tangle can be cut with a single fix, or that confrontation is safe, or that a landmark victory exists — none of that is true. What it claims is narrower and real: that honest science, showing a lake that fluctuates rather than vanishes, is itself a corrective to the false premise behind a risky grand scheme; that Transaqua and its like can be rigorously scrutinised through environmental review and the transboundary frameworks; that the shared waters are governed by the Lake Chad Basin Commission and reach the Congo basin's own stake; that the oil can be held to account for its broken promises; and that the humanitarian stake reaches the world. The levers are constrained, the work careful and science-grounded, and the prize is a risky scheme scrutinised, the oil held to account, and the true livelihoods defended — not a triumphant rescue. But in a poor, contested, transboundary basin, that careful, honest, science-grounded effort — protecting the vulnerable and avoiding the conflict — is not a lesser ambition. It is the responsible and effective one.